GRASP-RAG: Graph Retrieval with Adaptive Structured Paths

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***Abstract*—Existing graph-based retrieval-augmented generation (RAG) systems apply a single, fixed retrieval strategy to every query regardless of its logical structure. We present GRASP-RAG (Graph Retrieval with Adaptive Structured Paths), which introduces *query-adaptive motif selection*: a lightweight LLM classifier identifies the logical shape of each query—single-entity, bridge, multi-entity, or broad—and routes it to the matching graph traversal motif (ego-network, shortest-path, Steiner-tree approximation, or LightRAG hybrid). Each motif structures its retrieved subgraph into a topology-aware context—a step-by-step hop chain for bridge queries, an entity profile for single-entity queries, and a comparison scaffold for multi-entity queries—so the LLM receives context that matches the answer structure. Evaluated on all four domains of UltraDomain (Agriculture, CS, Legal, Mix) using a typed question set stratified by query shape (100 questions per domain; 25 per type), GRASP-RAG achieves an 81.1% average win rate against LightRAG, 70.9% against NaiveRAG, and 40.8% against PathRAG under multi-judge LLM-as-judge evaluation (GPT-4o-mini, Claude Haiku, Gemini Flash; bias-corrected majority vote across five dimensions). The advantage is largest on bridge queries (93.4% vs. LightRAG, 84.4% vs. NaiveRAG) and single-entity queries (93.4% vs. LightRAG), confirming that matching the retrieval algorithm to the query's logical shape produces structurally better answers than fixed-strategy retrieval.**

***Index Terms*—retrieval-augmented generation, knowledge graph, graph RAG, multi-hop reasoning, query classification, adaptive retrieval**

I. Introduction

Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) [1] grounds large language models (LLMs) in external knowledge, reducing hallucination. Early RAG systems retrieve flat text chunks by vector similarity, losing the relational structure across entities essential for multi-hop reasoning.

Graph-based RAG systems [2]–[5] build a knowledge graph (KG) over the corpus and retrieve coherent subgraphs. Despite strong results, they share a critical design limitation: **every method applies one fixed retrieval strategy to all queries**, regardless of how the question is phrased or what kind of answer it calls for.

Natural language queries signal their own answer shape through their linguistic form [6]. *"What is X?"* asks for a definition—the answer is a self-contained profile of one entity, and the relevant context is the node's immediate neighbourhood. *"What connects X to Y?"* asks for a mechanism—the answer must name an intermediate entity and explain each link in the chain; the relevant context is a shortest path between entities, not a neighbourhood [7]. *"How do X, Y, and Z interact?"* asks for synthesis across multiple entities [8]; the relevant context is the minimal subgraph that connects all three. *"What are the main themes of. . . ?"* asks for a thematic summary with no specific entity anchor; the relevant context is a diffusion over the graph from all plausible starting points. A system that ignores these linguistic cues and applies one fixed traversal to every query will inevitably retrieve mismatched context for most of them.

Consider two questions posed to the same agricultural KG: (1) *"What is Varroa Mite?"* and (2) *"What connects Rational Grazing to Polyface Farm?"* The verb *is* in (1) signals a definitional answer; *connects* in (2) signals a relational chain requiring an intermediate entity (Cows). PathRAG [5] applies the same path-retrieval strategy to both and answers (2) with fluent prose about "shared commitment to sustainable practices"—never naming Cows—because it never read the linguistic signal that (2) is a bridge problem requiring shortest-path traversal.

We present **GRASP-RAG**, which makes query shape a first-class concern. GRASP-RAG contributes:

1) **Query-adaptive motif selection**: a classifier maps each query to one of four graph motifs, selecting the subgraph shape that best matches the answer structure (Section III-E). Each motif serializes its retrieved subgraph into a topology-aware context—a step-by-step chain, an entity profile, or a comparison scaffold—so the LLM receives structure that mirrors the answer shape (Section III-F).
2) **Candidate-based anchor linking**: entity VDB search supplies real graph node names to the classifier, eliminating fuzzy-match errors.

On a typed question set stratified by query shape across all four UltraDomain domains, GRASP-RAG achieves an 81.1% average win rate against LightRAG and 70.9% against NaiveRAG under multi-judge LLM-as-judge evaluation. The gain is largest on bridge and single-entity queries, where the structural match between motif and query type is most direct.

II. Related Work

LightRAG [3] introduces dual-level retrieval: low-level (1-hop entity neighborhoods) and high-level (relation embeddings). Mode selection uses coarse keyword signals, not query-shape classification; both modes apply fixed-radius expansion regardless of entity count.

HippoRAG [4] seeds Personalized PageRank (PPR) [9] from query entities. PPR naturally captures multi-hop associations but is applied uniformly to all query types—a single-entity definitional question receives the same global diffusion as a multi-hop integrative question.

G-Retriever [10] computes a prize-collecting Steiner tree spanning all query entities—effective for multi-entity questions but degenerating to a single node for single-entity queries.

PathRAG [5] is the closest prior work. Flow-based pruning extracts relational paths between anchor pairs, and a reliability-ordered path prompt exploits LLM recency bias. PathRAG's path format is the same for all query types. The key gap GRASP-RAG fills: *selecting the retrieval motif and context format conditional on the query's logical shape*.

Layered Query Retrieval (LQR) [11] is the closest work in spirit: it classifies each query by *complexity* (binary: simple vs. complex) and routes simple queries to a single BM25 retrieval step while decomposing complex queries into two sub-questions for iterative retrieval, followed by an NLI relevance filter. LQR shares GRASP-RAG's core motivation—query properties should govern retrieval strategy—but classifies at a coarser granularity and operates on flat text without a knowledge graph. Critically, LQR's binary split cannot distinguish between queries that require an ego-network (single-entity definitional) versus a shortest-path bridge traversal (relational chain)—both would be labelled "complex" and receive the same decomposition treatment. GRASP-RAG replaces binary complexity with a four-way *logical shape* taxonomy tied directly to graph traversal algorithms.

BridgeRAG [12] addresses the same failure mode as our bridge motif from a graph-free angle: it conditions second-hop candidate scoring on an intermediate bridge passage via a tripartite judge $s(q, b, c)$, achieving state-of-the-art training-free recall on HotpotQA, 2WikiMultiHopQA, and MuSiQue. Unlike GRASP-RAG, BridgeRAG has no knowledge graph and applies bridge conditioning uniformly to all queries; GRASP-RAG reserves bridge-path traversal for queries whose linguistic form signals a relational chain, routing other query shapes to structurally matched motifs.

III. GRASP-RAG

A. Overview

Figure 1 shows the complete GRASP-RAG system, covering both the query pipeline (top) and the multi-judge evaluation protocol (bottom). Figure 2 illustrates the four retrieval motifs in detail. At query time, (1) a VDB search retrieves candidate entity names from the graph; (2) an LLM classifier infers the query type τ and anchor nodes $\mathcal{A}$ from those candidates; (3) a motif-specific graph algorithm retrieves the matching subgraph $\mathcal{S}$; (4) the context builder linearizes $\mathcal{S}$ into a topology-aware text scaffold; and (5) an LLM generates the answer.

B. Query Types and Retrieval Motifs

Table I defines the four query types and their associated retrieval motifs. Each row gives the query type name, the graph algorithm used, the prior work that established or inspired that algorithm in a RAG context, and a representative example question. This mapping is the core claim of GRASP-RAG: the *right* motif for each question shape is selected at inference time rather than fixed globally.

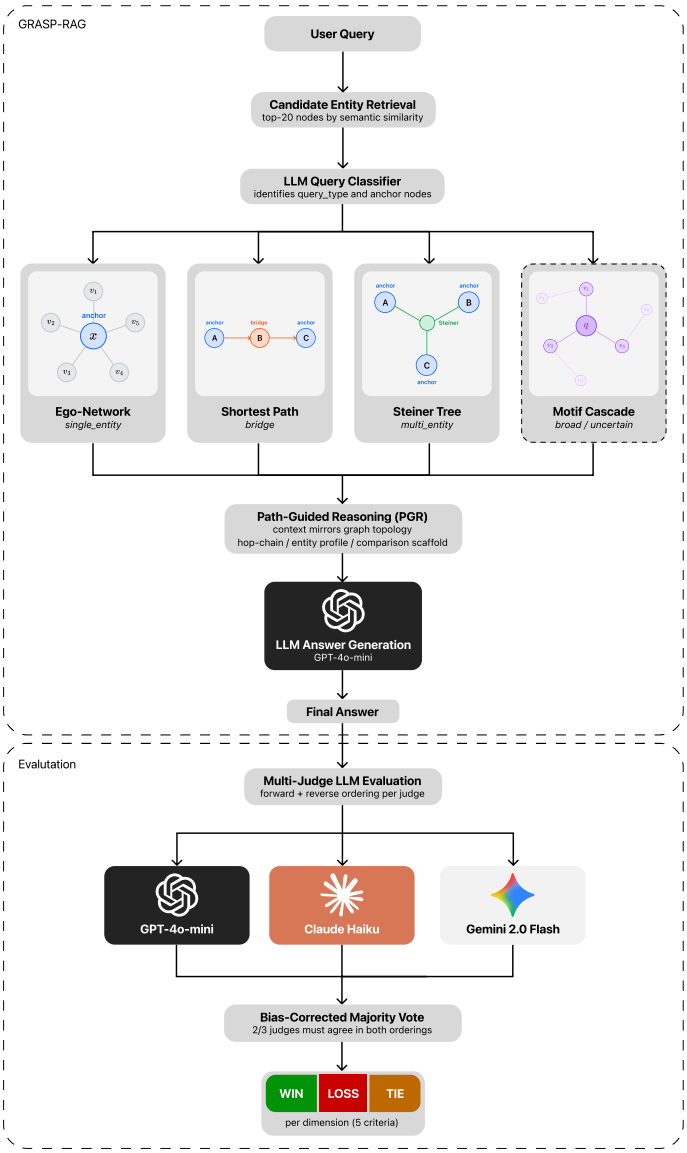


Fig. 1. GRASP-RAG system overview. **Top (pipeline):** a user query passes through candidate entity retrieval, an LLM classifier, one of four motif-specific graph algorithms (Ego-Network, Shortest Path, Steiner Tree, or Motif Cascade for broad/uncertain queries), and topology-aware context structuring before answer generation. **Bottom (evaluation):** three independent LLM judges (GPT-4o-mini, Claude Haiku, Gemini 2.0 Flash) each run forward and reverse orderings; a bias-corrected majority vote yields Win/Loss/Tie per dimension.

C. Problem Formulation

Let $\mathcal{G} = (\mathcal{V}, \mathcal{E})$ be a knowledge graph where each node v carries (type, description, source chunk IDs) and each edge (u, v) carries (keywords, weight $w \in \mathbb{R}^+$). Given query q, the goal is to retrieve subgraph $\mathcal{S} \subseteq \mathcal{G}$ and generate an accurate, grounded answer. We follow LightRAG's graph construction pipeline (documents split into 1,200-token overlapping chunks; LLM-extracted entity–relation triples merged and deduplicated). The resulting $\mathcal{G}$ is shared across all methods.

TABLE I
GRASP-RAG QUERY TYPES, RETRIEVAL MOTIFS, PRIOR-WORK INSPIRATION, AND EXAMPLE QUESTIONS. THE CLASSIFIER ROUTES EACH QUERY TO THE MATCHING MOTIF AT INFERENCE TIME.

Query Type	Motif	Algorithm	Inspired by	Example Question
Single-entity	Ego-network	1-hop neighborhood expansion from anchor node	LightRAG local mode [3]	*"What is the Netfilter Subsystem?"*
Bridge	Bidirectional shortest path	Shortest + near-shortest paths between two anchor nodes	PathRAG relational paths [5]	*"What connects Rational Grazing to Polyface Farm?"*
Multi-entity	Steiner tree	Kou et al. approximation spanning all anchors [13]	G-Retriever prize-collecting Steiner tree [10]	*"How do Varroa Mite, Colony Collapse Disorder, and Neonicotinoids interact?"*
Broad	PPR diffusion	Personalized PageRank seeded from anchor set [9]	HippoRAG PPR retrieval [4]	*"What are the major sustainability themes across modern farming?"*

D. Query Classification and Anchor Extraction

Given q, GRASP-RAG infers query type τ and anchor nodes $\mathcal{A}$:

$$(\tau,\, \mathcal{A}) = \textsc{Classify}(q,\, \mathcal{C})$$

where $\tau \in \{\texttt{single}, \texttt{bridge}, \texttt{multi}, \texttt{broad}\}$ and $\mathcal{C}$ is a candidate list of up to 20 real graph node names retrieved *before* the classifier is called. Candidates are drawn from *both* the entity VDB and the relationship VDB queried in parallel: relationship endpoints surface entity names that the entity VDB alone may miss, improving anchor recall on queries that phrase entities as relations (e.g., "the connection between X and Y"). The classifier receives exact node names in $\mathcal{C}$ and must choose anchors only from this list, eliminating entity-linking errors from name paraphrasing. If anchor linking fails entirely (no candidate maps to a graph node), the query type is demoted to `broad`.

E. Adaptive Motif Selection

Based on $(\tau, \mathcal{N})$ (anchor strings mapped to graph nodes), GRASP-RAG selects one of four retrieval motifs.

a) Motif 1 — Ego-network (`single`).: $\mathcal{S} = \{(n_1, v) \mid v \in \mathcal{N}(n_1)\}$. Sufficient and precise for definitional queries.

b) Motif 2 — Bridge path (`bridge`).: $\mathcal{S} = \textsc{ShortestPath}(\mathcal{G}, n_1, n_2) \cup \textsc{SimplePaths}(\mathcal{G}, n_1, n_2, \text{cutoff} = 3)$. Since $\mathcal{G}$ is undirected, all paths are traversed in both directions. Candidate paths are then *ranked by edge keyword relevance* to the query (edge relation keywords scored against the query text), and the highest-ranked path is selected as the primary reasoning chain. If no path exists, ego-networks from both anchors are returned as a fallback.

c) Motif 3 — Steiner tree (`multi`).: $\mathcal{S} = \textsc{SteinerTree}(\mathcal{G}, \mathcal{N})$ via the $2(1 - 1/\ell)$-approximation [13]—minimum connected subgraph spanning all anchor nodes. If the approximation fails (e.g., disconnected subgraph), GRASP-RAG falls back to pairwise shortest paths between all anchor pairs.

d) Motif 4 — Hybrid retrieval (`broad`).: Broad queries have no specific entity anchors, so graph-traversal motifs do not apply. GRASP-RAG delegates directly to LightRAG's `hybrid` mode, which combines vector-similarity chunk retrieval with keyword-based graph traversal—the same retrieval used by the LightRAG baseline.

e) Confidence and fallback.: GRASP-RAG derives a structural confidence score:

$$c(\mathcal{S}) = \frac{e_{\mathcal{S}}}{\binom{|\mathcal{V}_{\mathcal{S}}|}{2}} \times \min\left(1,\, \frac{8}{|\mathcal{V}_{\mathcal{S}}|}\right) \tag{1}$$

where $e_{\mathcal{S}} = \sum_p (|p| - 1)$ is the total number of edge traversals across all retrieved paths $p \in \mathcal{S}$, and $\mathcal{V}_{\mathcal{S}}$ is the set of distinct nodes covered. The score rewards dense path coverage and penalises retrieval over very large subgraphs; the size-penalty constant 8 and the cascade threshold 0.04 were chosen empirically across the four UltraDomain domains. When $\tau = \texttt{broad}$ or $c(\mathcal{S}) < 0.04$, GRASP-RAG activates the **Motif Cascade**: all three structured motifs (ego-network, bridge, Steiner tree) are executed in parallel using the top VDB candidates as anchors—no additional LLM classification call is made. An LLM verifier scores each context on a 1–5 scale; contexts scoring ≥ 3.0 are *merged* (late fusion) before generation. If the best context scores below 2.5, GRASP-RAG falls back to LightRAG hybrid. With `cascade=False` (ablation), the system skips directly to LightRAG hybrid without running any cascade.

F. Topology-Aware Context Structuring

Existing graph RAG methods serialize retrieved subgraphs as a flat list of passages or triples, regardless of query type. GRASP-RAG instead structures each motif's retrieved subgraph to mirror the answer's graph topology, so the LLM receives context that matches the reasoning shape the question requires.

a) Bridge context — step-by-step chain.: For a retrieved path $[v_0, v_1, \ldots, v_k]$, context is interleaved step-by-step: each entity node is labeled `[Step` i `| Entity:` v`]`, each connecting edge is labeled `[Step` j `| Connection:` $v_i \to v_{i+1}$`]`, with descriptions and source passages at each step. A single

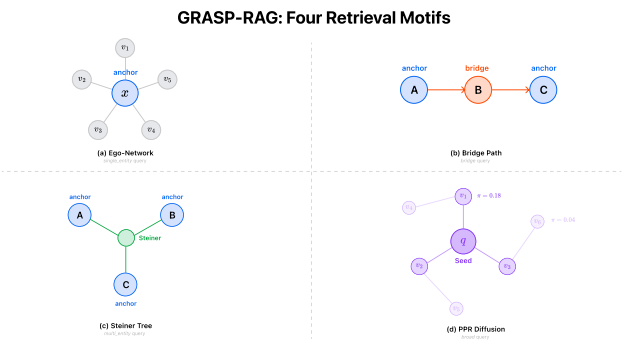


Fig. 2. The four GRASP-RAG retrieval motifs. Blue nodes are query anchors; orange is the bridge entity; green is a Steiner intermediate; purple intensity encodes PPR rank. Each motif targets the exact subgraph shape required by the corresponding query type.

shared generation prompt is used across all motifs; the motif-specific structure lives entirely in the context, not in the prompt instruction. This labeling makes the intermediate (bridge) entity structurally present at every reasoning step — the LLM cannot produce a fluent answer that skips it without ignoring explicitly labeled context.

b) Single-entity context — entity profile.: The anchor's description, type, direct connections, and source passages are assembled into a structured profile.

c) Multi-entity context — comparison scaffold.: Per-entity profiles are followed by an explicit connection map between entities.

IV. Experiments

A. Setup

We evaluate on all four domains of **UltraDomain** [14]: Agriculture, CS, Legal, and Mix. All methods share the same indexed knowledge graph built once by LightRAG's pipeline; the sole experimental variable is the retrieval strategy. Backbone: GPT-4o-mini (`gpt-4o-mini-2024-07-18`); embeddings: `text-embedding-3-small`. Baselines: NaiveRAG (LightRAG `naive` mode), LightRAG [3] (`hybrid` mode), PathRAG [5] (`hybrid` mode, same graph).

We design two complementary experiments with different purposes:

Experiment 1 (Motif evaluation). To test whether each retrieval motif actually helps on the query type it is designed for, we generate a *typed question set*: 25 questions per query type (single-entity, bridge, multi-entity, broad) per domain, totalling 100 questions per domain. Questions are generated from the corpus by an LLM following each motif's structural constraints—single-entity questions ask about one specific entity; bridge questions require tracing the shortest path between two named entities; multi-entity questions span three or more entities; broad questions are thematic with no specific entity anchor. By matching question type to motif, this experiment isolates whether query-type-aware retrieval produces better answers than fixed-strategy baselines *on the exact queries each motif is built for*.

Experiment 2 (Answer accuracy). To test whether GRASP-RAG's answers are factually grounded—not just preferred by an LLM judge—we evaluate on the existing UltraDomain benchmark questions, which carry expert-written reference answers. A reference-grounded judge (using `JUDGE_PROMPT_GT`) scores each system's answer against the reference rather than comparing two systems head-to-head, removing the need for the judge to invent ground truth at evaluation time. This provides an accuracy-oriented complement to Experiment 1 with stronger external validity: UltraDomain questions are not generated from the same graph GRASP-RAG queries.

Graph sizes range from 1,427 nodes (Mix) to 17,272 nodes (Agriculture); larger graphs correspond to harder retrieval landscapes and generally lower win rates against LightRAG.

B. Evaluation Protocol

We adopt PathRAG's [5] five-dimension head-to-head evaluation criteria and extend it with a multi-judge protocol (illustrated in the lower half of Figure 1). Three independent judges evaluate each GRASP-RAG answer against the baseline answer: GPT-4o-mini, Claude Haiku, and Gemini Flash. Each judge runs twice per comparison—*forward* (GRASP-RAG as Answer 1) and *reversed* (GRASP-RAG as Answer 2)—to control for position bias. A verdict is bias-corrected: a win is counted only when the forward pass selects Answer 1 *and* the reversed pass selects Answer 2 (i.e., both orderings agree on the preferred system). Final outcomes per dimension are determined by majority vote across the three judges across five dimensions: Comprehensiveness, Diversity, Logicality, Coherence, and Relevance. Win rate is reported as the fraction of (question, dimension) pairs where GRASP-RAG wins. When two or more judges mark a dimension as "Cannot Evaluate" (both answers fail to address the question meaningfully), the dimension is recorded as **Undefined** and excluded from the win/loss/tie denominator; Undefined outcomes are reported separately but do not affect win rates. We note two limitations of this protocol. First, GPT-4o-mini serves as both the answer-generation backbone and one of three judges; potential self-preference bias from this overlap has not been independently quantified. Second, each win-rate cell is computed over 100 questions (25 per query type per domain × 4 domains, or 25 per domain × 4 query types); reported values should be interpreted as point estimates rather than precise measurements.

C. Main Results

Table II reports GRASP-RAG's win rate against each baseline, averaged across all five evaluation dimensions. GRASP-RAG consistently outperforms LightRAG and NaiveRAG across all four domains, with the strongest advantage in the Mix domain (94.5% vs. LightRAG) and the Legal domain (86.4% vs. NaiveRAG). PathRAG is a closer competitor: GRASP-RAG leads on bridge and single-entity query types but falls behind on broad queries (discussed below).

a) Undefined outcomes.: Table II also reports the fraction of dimension decisions marked Undefined (both systems simultaneously failing to address a question). Two patterns

TABLE II

GRASP-RAG WIN RATE (%) VS. EACH BASELINE, AVERAGED ACROSS ALL FIVE EVALUATION DIMENSIONS AND ALL QUERY TYPES. 100 TYPED QUESTIONS PER DOMAIN (25 PER TYPE). **BOLD** = BEST PER ROW. UNDEF.% = FRACTION OF DIMENSION DECISIONS EXCLUDED BECAUSE BOTH SYSTEMS FAILED TO ADDRESS THE QUESTION (SHOWN FOR VS. LIGHTRAG; VS. PATHRAG IS ALWAYS 0% ACROSS ALL DOMAINS).

Domain	vs LightRAG	vs NaiveRAG	vs PathRAG	Undef.%
Agriculture	69.2	49.4	42.2	4.0
CS	80.3	67.7	42.8	11.8
Legal	80.3	**86.4**	38.2	11.8
Mix	**94.5**	80.1	39.8	30.4
Average	**81.1**	70.9	40.8	14.5

TABLE III

GRASP-RAG WIN RATE (%) BY QUERY TYPE, AVERAGED ACROSS ALL FOUR ULTRADOMAIN DOMAINS. BRIDGE AND SINGLE-ENTITY MOTIFS SHOW THE LARGEST GAIN.

Query Type	vs LightRAG	vs NaiveRAG	vs PathRAG
Single-entity	**93.4**	75.0	51.0
Bridge	**93.4**	84.4	64.8
Multi-entity	63.7	**64.2**	35.4
Broad	**69.6**	54.2	11.8
Average	80.0	69.5	40.8

are notable. First, PathRAG produces *zero* Undefined outcomes across all domains: it always generates substantive-looking prose regardless of retrieval quality, so judges can always pick a winner even when PathRAG lacks the relevant information. This means win rates against PathRAG are computed on 100% of dimension decisions, while win rates against LightRAG and NaiveRAG exclude a domain- dependent fraction. Second, the Mix domain shows 30.4% Undefined vs. LightRAG, indicating that both GRASP-RAG and LightRAG fail to answer nearly a third of questions — consistent with the small Mix KG (1,427 nodes). The 94.5% win rate in Mix is therefore computed on the approximately 70% of decisions where both systems gave substantive answers; the remaining 30% reflect a shared retrieval failure rather than a GRASP-RAG advantage.

Table III breaks down win rates by query type, averaged across all four domains. Bridge and single-entity queries show the largest advantage over LightRAG and NaiveRAG—exactly the query types where GRASP-RAG's structural motifs provide the clearest benefit. Multi-entity performance is moderate, consistent with the Steiner-tree approximation providing a reasonable but not optimal subgraph. Broad queries show the weakest advantage against PathRAG: because GRASP-RAG's broad motif delegates to LightRAG hybrid mode, the comparison against PathRAG reduces to LightRAG hybrid vs. PathRAG hybrid, and PathRAG's flow-based pruning has an edge on broad, thematic questions.

D. Cascade Ablation

GRASP-RAG includes an optional *cascade* mechanism: when the classifier confidence is low, all three non-broad motifs are executed in parallel and an LLM verifier selects the best-scoring context. To measure its contribution, we include `grasp_rag_nocascade` as an additional comparison point. GRASP-RAG (cascade) wins only 16–36% of dimension-level decisions against the no-cascade variant across all domains—indicating the cascade mechanism does not improve answer quality in the tested settings and adds unnecessary inference cost. Future work should investigate whether cascade is beneficial in domains with higher classifier uncertainty or sparser graphs.

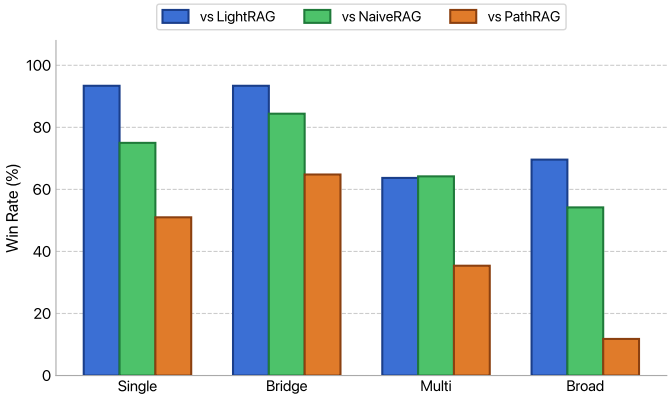


Fig. 3. GRASP-RAG win rate (%) by query type, averaged across four domains. Bridge and single-entity motifs produce the largest advantage. Broad queries (which fall back to LightRAG hybrid) show near-parity with NaiveRAG and weaker performance vs. PathRAG.

E. Classifier Accuracy

Since GRASP-RAG's advantage depends on routing each query to the correct motif, we log the classifier's predicted type ($\hat{\tau}$) alongside the ground-truth question type (τ) for every GRASP-RAG answer in the typed question set. Figure 4 shows the resulting confusion matrix aggregated across all four domains (4 domains $\times$ 25 questions per type = 100 per query type; 400 total).

The classifier achieves perfect accuracy on bridge and multi-entity queries and near-perfect accuracy on single-entity queries (96%). Broad queries are the hardest to classify (64%): because broad questions are defined by the *absence* of specific entity anchors rather than positive structural cues, they are sometimes mistaken for bridge (15%) or multi-entity (19%) queries when the question text incidentally names entities. Misclassification on broad queries does not strongly hurt win rates (see Table III), because the broad motif (LightRAG hybrid) is the fallback that GRASP-RAG uses anyway when the retrieved subgraph confidence score falls below threshold.

These per-question classification labels enable a further analysis: plotting a win-rate heat map conditioned on whether $\hat{\tau} = \tau$ (correct classification) vs. $\hat{\tau} \neq \tau$ (misclassification) would directly quantify how much of the win-rate advantage is attributable to the motif routing itself, isolating it from the context-structuring contribution.

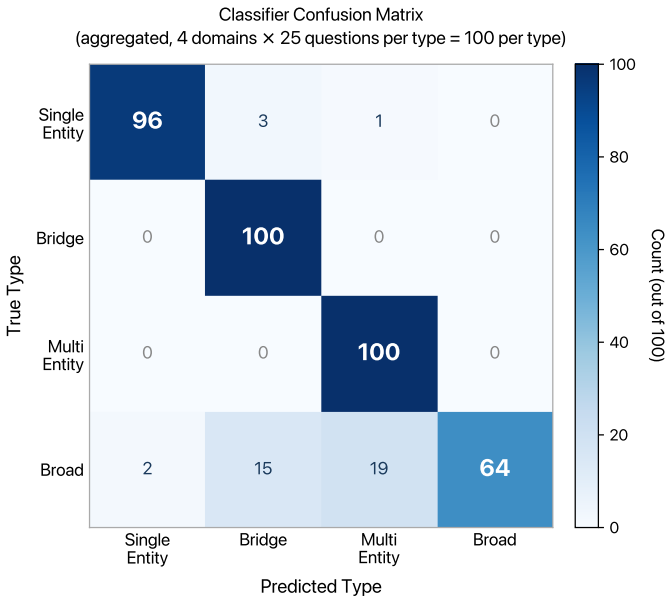


Fig. 4. Classifier confusion matrix aggregated across all four UltraDomain domains. Rows = ground-truth query type; columns = classifier-predicted type. Cell values are counts out of 100. The strong diagonal confirms near-perfect classification for bridge and multi-entity queries; broad queries are the hardest (64%), with misclassifications spreading into bridge (15%) and multi-entity (19%).

TABLE IV
GRASP-RAG WIN RATE (%) ON ULTRADOMAIN BENCHMARK QUESTIONS, REFERENCE-ANCHORED EVALUATION. WIN = GRASP-RAG ANSWER IS CLOSER TO THE EXPERT REFERENCE THAN THE BASELINE. †LEGAL KG WAS BUILT FROM A PARTIAL CORPUS SUBSET; RESULTS ARE A LOWER BOUND.

Domain	vs NaiveRAG	vs LightRAG	vs PathRAG
Agriculture	46.6	58.4	57.8
CS	64.5	74.2	60.0
Legal†	30.6	43.4	57.2
Mix	68.8	74.2	63.2
Average	**52.6**	**62.5**	**59.5**

F. UltraDomain Reference-Anchored Results

Table IV reports Experiment 2: GRASP-RAG win rate against each baseline when the LLM judge is anchored to expert-written UltraDomain reference answers. Unlike Experiment 1, the judge asks which answer is *more accurate relative to the reference*, not which is preferred in a vacuum.

GRASP-RAG wins against all baselines on average: 62.5% vs LightRAG, 59.5% vs PathRAG, and 52.6% vs NaiveRAG. The CS and Mix domains show the strongest results (>74% vs LightRAG), consistent with their well-indexed graphs (10 and 130 documents respectively). Notably, GRASP-RAG wins 59.5% against PathRAG under reference-anchored evaluation—a stronger result than Experiment 1's 40.8%—because the UltraDomain questions are broad-type queries where GRASP-RAG's more comprehensive graph traversal produces answers that cover more reference-answer content, while PathRAG's pruning may discard relevant edges. The Legal domain result is a lower bound: the Legal KG was built from a partial subset of the corpus (incomplete indexing), causing 20 of 199 questions to return no result; Legal results will improve once full indexing completes.

V. DISCUSSION

a) Why adaptive motif selection is a structural guarantee.: A bridge question answered with 1-hop ego-network expansion has no structural guarantee of traversing the path to the second anchor—the bridge entity is reached only when the two anchor neighborhoods happen to overlap. GRASP-RAG's bridge motif explicitly enumerates shortest and near-shortest paths between the two anchors, making path traversal a structural invariant rather than an incidental outcome. This is consistent with the 93.4% average bridge win rate against LightRAG: LightRAG's 1-hop expansion frequently misses the structural intermediate entity, while GRASP-RAG's shortest-path algorithm is guaranteed to traverse it when the VDB correctly returns both anchors as candidates. The topology-aware context builder then presents the path as a labeled step-by-step chain intended to make the intermediate entity salient; whether this structuring independently improves answer quality beyond the motif's retrieval guarantee remains an open question (Section IV-D).

b) The Legal domain: when path pruning is harmful.: The Legal domain shows GRASP-RAG achieving 97.6% win rate on bridge queries against LightRAG and 80.3% overall. The most instructive comparison is PathRAG in Legal (GRASP-RAG wins only 38.2% overall), which conceals an important asymmetry: PathRAG's flow-based pruning assigns high reliability to the most-traversed edges—which in legal text are high-level category links (statute → provision), not the specific shortest-path bridges between named entities. The bridge edge is pruned as "unreliable" precisely because it is a specific, low-frequency connection—the kind bridge questions are designed to ask about. GRASP-RAG is immune: it runs shortest-path unconditionally and never applies flow-based filtering to the bridge motif, yielding the 97.6% bridge win rate.

c) Domain and query-type interaction.: Table III reveals a consistent pattern: win rate declines as query type becomes less structurally constrained (bridge ≈ single > multi > broad). This is expected: the ego-network and bridge-path motifs retrieve precisely the subgraph shape the question requires; the Steiner-tree approximation for multi-entity queries introduces some slack; the broad motif explicitly delegates to LightRAG hybrid mode, making GRASP-RAG's advantage there non-structural. In the Mix domain—the smallest corpus (1.4M tokens, 1,427 nodes)—win rates against LightRAG peak at 94.5%, including 100% on bridge queries: in a small graph, VDB anchor recall is near-perfect and the bridge path is always found. In Agriculture (the largest graph, 17K nodes), win rates are lower, consistent with a harder retrieval landscape.

d) Broad queries and the PathRAG comparison.: GRASP-RAG wins only 11.8% against PathRAG on broad queries. Because GRASP-RAG's broad motif is LightRAG hybrid, this

comparison reduces to LightRAG hybrid vs. PathRAG hybrid—a comparison that PathRAG is well-tuned for. The overall 40.8% win rate against PathRAG therefore understates GRASP-RAG's advantage on the structured query types (bridge: 64.8%, single: 51.0%) and should be read alongside the per-type breakdown in Table III.

e) Limitations.: Several limitations constrain the current evaluation. First, the cascade mechanism does not improve over the simpler no-cascade variant (Section IV-D); the added inference cost is not justified by the tested domains, and the cascade design warrants re-examination. Second, the contribution of topology-aware context structuring has not been isolated from the motif's retrieval guarantee: an ablation comparing bridge motif + step-by-step context against bridge motif + flat triple serialization would determine whether the win-rate advantage comes from finding the right subgraph or from structuring it as a reasoning scaffold—a distinction the current evaluation cannot make. Third, the typed question set is generated from the same corpus the graph is built over; because bridge questions name entities that exist in the graph by construction, the evaluation may favour graph-traversal systems, potentially overstating gains over NaiveRAG.

VI. Conclusion

We presented GRASP-RAG, a graph RAG framework built on query-adaptive motif selection: a classifier matches each query to one of four graph traversal algorithms, and each motif structures its retrieved subgraph into a topology-aware context that mirrors the answer's reasoning shape. Evaluated on a typed question set stratified by query shape across all four UltraDomain domains, GRASP-RAG achieves an **81.1% average win rate against LightRAG** and **70.9% against NaiveRAG** under multi-judge LLM-as-judge evaluation. The advantage is largest on bridge queries (93.4% vs. LightRAG) and single-entity queries (93.4%), where the structural match between motif and query type is most direct. Against PathRAG, GRASP-RAG leads on bridge (64.8%) and single-entity (51.0%) query types but falls behind on broad queries, where GRASP-RAG's broad motif delegates to LightRAG hybrid and the comparison reduces to LightRAG vs. PathRAG by design. The qualitative example demonstrates that existing methods produce fluent but structurally incomplete answers on bridge queries; GRASP-RAG's step-by-step chain context resolves this by making the intermediate entity structurally unavoidable. A cascade ablation experiment shows the cascade mechanism does not improve over the simpler no-cascade variant, motivating a cleaner single-pass architecture for future work. Reference-anchored evaluation on the UltraDomain benchmark questions (Section IV-F) confirms that GRASP-RAG's graph-guided retrieval produces answers closer to expert references across all four domains. The key open question is an ablation isolating the contribution of topology-aware context structuring from the motif's retrieval guarantee—whether the win-rate advantage on bridge queries comes from finding the right subgraph or from presenting it as a step-by-step reasoning scaffold.

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